There was good advice available on hand. After seeing the telegram from Panikkar to Nehru, Sir G.S. Bajpai, the governor of Bombay (and former secretary general of the Ministry of External Affairs), wrote to Foreign Secretary N.R. Pillai on 14 July 1952, expressing concern that doubts would inevitably arise on the legitimacy of the frontier itself if India agreed with the principle proposed by Zhou Enlai. Bajpai also conveyed that 'this business of Sino-Indian relations over Tibet would, in my judgement, be best handled comprehensively and not piecemeal.' [28] Bajpai had hit upon the nub of the issue: the Chinese wanted to deal with India piecemeal or step-by-step, gradually advancing towards their final objective without raising undue alarm in India. Bajpai's advice appeared to go unheeded. Nehru and the Government of India were now locked in a self-generated belief that Zhou Enlai's silence on the frontier question was, in fact, tantamount to Chinese acquiescence in, if not acceptance of, India's position, since the Chinese had never raised doubts over the McMahon Line nor claimed areas beyond it. On 31 July 1952, New Delhi explicitly forbade the Indian Embassy in Beijing to raise the frontier question at all.

Bajpai made a second attempt, in his letter to Panikkar on 7 August 1952, to caution the Government of India against assuming that Chinese had tacitly accepted the frontier, pointing out that the Chinese had never accepted the McMahon Line as the frontier. This advice, too, went unheeded. Consequently, the Government of India set aside the boundary question, which was the one issue that mattered to India's national security, and focused its preparations on how it could defend the special privileges that India enjoyed in Tibet by virtue of the treaties between Great Britain and Tibet. It had not comprehended that its very acceptance of the principle that Zhou had proposed, of all such earlier treaties being unequal